thirty to forty minutes late in returning to its base. McNamara excused himself and left the room to call Rusk. Through him, the news eventually reached Kennedy.[3]

Roger Hilsman, the Department of State chief of intelligence, found the president in the White House soon after he had taken his usual afternoon swim to ease his back pain. He told Kennedy that the Air Force had a U-2 reconnaissance plane over the Soviet Union being pursued by Soviet fighters. American fighters were now in the air trying to protect it. “The implications were as obvious as they were horrendous,” wrote Hilsman, recalling his own assessment of the situation. “The Soviets might well regard the U-2 as a last-minute intelligence reconnaissance in preparation for nuclear war.”

John Kennedy took the news rather stoically, if not philosophically: “There is always some sonofabitch who doesn’t get the word.” Having served in the Navy during World War II, he had little trust in the military carrying out orders as received. Kennedy understood what was at stake. He could not but remember the crisis caused by the downing of a U-2 plane over the Soviet Union in 1960, which had derailed the planned summit between Eisenhower and Khrushchev. Now, in the middle of a much more serious crisis, a U-2 lost over Soviet territory might very well lead to war.[4]

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UNLIKE CAPTAIN GARY POWERS’S ILL-FATED FLIGHT OVER the Soviet Union on May 1, 1960, Captain Charles (Chuck) Maultsby’s incursion into Soviet airspace on October 27, 1962, was not premeditated. Like Powers, Maultsby was collecting evidence needed to assess Soviet activity, but he had no intention of venturing into the skies over the USSR. Maultsby, who had been shot down over Korea during the Korean War and spent twenty-two months in Chinese imprisonment, had no desire to conduct a comparative study of communist prisons and labor camps. He was supposed to collect air samples outside Soviet borders but simply lost his way.

As a participant in “Project Star Dust,” Maultsby had orders to fly his Lockheed U-2 spy plane to the North Pole, take samples of air that might or